

The History of the Regional Ethnology of Scotland Project (RESP)

Regional Ethnology of Scotland Project (RESP)

Following completion of the 14-volume 'Scottish Life and Society: A Compendium of Scottish Ethnology', the EERC launched the Regional Ethnology of Scotland Project (RESP), in 2011. The aim of the Project was to enhance the Compendium by facilitating the collection of primary source material that would illustrate everyday life and society in Scotland, past and present. After an initial scoping study, Dumfries and Galloway was chosen as the first research area and it was determined that the Study would have two distinct parts: the spoken word and the written word. From the outset, key objectives included i) the involvement of local partners and volunteers and ii) implementing a process which would allow the research materials generated by the Project to be shared as widely as possible.

RESP: The spoken word

EERC staff worked with local organisations and partners and held events to promote the RESP and recruit volunteer fieldworkers and potential interviewees. Volunteer fieldworkers were then trained in all aspects of fieldwork, from practical equipment operation to ethical guidance. The fieldworkers were then provided with ongoing support from the EERC staff as they embarked on their fieldwork. This began with detailed feedback on initial interviews and included the provision of a shared reflective diary, where fieldworkers were encouraged to reflect on their own practice and share their thoughts on what they had learned from each interview so that others could read the entries and learn from them. Organised fieldworker gatherings, where participating fieldworkers were encouraged to reflect and talk about the material they had collected were also part of this. During the active years of the Dumfries and Galloway RESP (2011-2018), around 80 volunteer fieldworkers made recordings with nearly 400 interviewees, amounting to around 300 hours of fieldwork recordings.

The decision to recruit local volunteer fieldworkers was central to the Project and had a number of beneficial outcomes. Most importantly, the Project sought to gather a body of source material which would represent the priorities and concerns of the Study region. By training locally-based volunteer fieldworkers and then letting them decide who to interview and what questions to ask, it was hoped an un-mediated impression of local experience could emerge. In addition, by including local partners and volunteer fieldworkers, the EERC were able to maximise the work that could be achieved during the Study period and this led to a dynamic and invigorating experience for everyone involved.

In the introduction to volume 1 of the Compendium of Scottish Ethnology (p.26), Margaret Mackay includes this quote from Sandy Fenton, which remains a guiding principle of the RESP:

[Ethnology] is a subject that relates to each and every one of us and there is no one who cannot be a practitioner. It is one in which personal roots, the home and environment within which the researcher is brought up, become part of the research apparatus of national identity.

In practice, we can look at examples such as Margaret Smith, who came to the RESP as an enthusiastic but unsure volunteer who didn't think she could be a fieldworker. Margaret went on to make 42 recordings with 44 interviewees between 2014 and 2017. The focus of her fieldwork was primarily nursing (her own profession) and later expanded to include fieldwork with workers from

industries in Dumfriesshire, such as ICI. Margaret spoke about her work publicly and her recordings with nurses are the focus of a forthcoming *Flashback*. Her fieldwork provides tremendous insights into life and society, especially on the theme of working life.

In addition to the active collecting, a small number of items and pre-existing collections were donated to the Project, thereby ensuring wider access to these recordings and ongoing care and security of this valuable legacy resource. This included the first recordings to be added to the RESP Archive, a series of interviews carried out between 1999 and 2016, comprising 42 recordings made with 46 contributors which had been made by members of the Stranraer and District Local History Trust. This rich body of material resulted in the first publication to be generated by the RESP, the Regional Flashback 'Stranraer and District Lives: Voices in Trust' (2017). Another donated item, a recording made by Ian Blacklock in 1975 with his 100-year-old granny, takes us back to the late 19th century and memories of seeing Queen Victoria, at the opening of the Manchester Ship Canal in 1894.

The RESP model has developed over time and is currently active in East Lothian with smaller projects in other parts of the country, such as work with the Harris Tweed Authority in the Western Isles, which are supported on a smaller scale and over a shorter time-frame.

To date, almost 300 fieldwork recordings have been added to the East Lothian collection. This includes both ongoing original fieldwork and donated material. To pick out just a few highlights:

- A series of interviews between a daughter and her father which explore changing land use in East Lothian from the perspective of a farmer. At a time when there is a huge expansion in housebuilding in East Lothian, many interviews in the East Lothian collection reflect on this expansion and the impact of this change on local communities. This can be in relation to current expansion and also includes other, older times of change, such as the Glasgow overspill or the expansion of smaller industrial communities, such as Tranent.
- Interviews conducted by primary 6 pupils with former pupils and members of staff as part of the centenary celebrations for Campie primary school in Musselburgh.
- Interviews with Pencaitland primary school pupils which explore what life is like for children growing up in East Lothian today.
- Interviews made in and around the village of Garvald which explore the rich history of this community and chart change over time, from Garvald as a popular holiday destination to a consideration of the changing relationship between the village and nearby Nunraw Abbey.
- A donated collection of material (EL2) collected in the 1970s-80s on a range of themes enables researchers to use the RESP resource to consider a longer time-frame for study across a wide range of themes including: housing, fishing, industry, community, foodways, social life, agriculture and education.

As the end of Project funding approaches, the East Lothian fieldwork collecting has been paused while we concentrate on finalising the existing materials so that these can be uploaded onto the website prior to summer 2027.

The RESP Archive Project

As mentioned above, a key principle of the RESP from the outset, was to make the resources as widely accessible as possible and this commitment led to the establishment of the RESP Archive Project and the collaboration with the Centre for Research Collections at the University of Edinburgh where the RESP fieldwork recordings are now held as part of their permanent collection.

As a born-digital collection, the RESP recordings were already cleared for digital release and so, in 2018, work began on building the resource which would become the RESP website <https://collections.ed.ac.uk/eerc/>. This website is accessible to everyone and provides access to the entire RESP collection. Each recording has been screened in order to comply with GDPR regulations, and redactions made as appropriate. The recordings for each interviewee appear on a dedicated web-page alongside any available visual resources, a detailed summary of the interview contents and full transcriptions. In this way, the RESP team have sought to make the recordings as accessible as possible. The resource continues to be added to with both original fieldwork recordings and legacy materials and this will be the main focus of staff resources for the remainder of the Project funding period (until summer 2027).

Over the years, the RESP Archive Project has been able to support a number of internships to enrich, enhance and promote access to the Collection. Colleagues from the wider CRC team, including exhibition and outreach professionals, have helped to nurture and mentor the interns to enhance their learning and to enable them to achieve the best possible results for the Project.

2022/23 – Denise Hick and Rowan Rush-Morgan. Development of an interactive map for the website which helps with geographical enquiries.

2023/24 – Rebekah Day and James Rice - Creation of an on-line exhibition, *Animal Encounters in the RESP Archive*, and various outreach initiatives and activities to promote the RESP, including development of the interactive *Kids Only* webpage on the RESP website.

2024/25 – Katie Shepherd and Ailsa Dixon. Dedicated fieldwork activity with the 20 members of the Sporting and Active Memories Group at JGC and the subsequent publication of *All in a Day's Work* in partnership with East Lothian Council.

Innovation: Being part of the wider CRC has meant that the EERC and the RESP Archive Team have been able to call on the expertise of a varied team of experts within the archives team. The Project has also provided a unique testing bed for the team working within the wider university (ISG) on digital preservation systems: allowing them to realise significant developments in this important area of archive work.

A key strength of the RESP model is that it is simple and agile and it has therefore been possible to respond to opportunities as they arise and to direct resources wisely to achieve the best impact. One recent development has been to move into film production as a way of using in-house expertise to develop resources which can reach a wide audience, encourage more participation in the RESP and create a resource that can be used in future, beyond the time the RESP is active.

RESP outputs so far include:

Printed resources:

Four books, including one edited by the volunteer fieldworker who conducted the research ('Whithorn: An Economy of People, 1920-1960'. Editor, Julia Muir Watt) and one joint-edited with a volunteer fieldworker ('Lochmaben: Community Memories'. Editors, Isabelle C Gow and Sheila Findlay). A further publication, on the subject of nursing, is currently under production (March 2026).

Representing and promoting the RESP Archive at various conferences and events and participating in outreach. For example:

- Prison outreach work: commenced in 2023, this work has been well received and continues in 2026.
- Responding to community requests to speak about the RESP or participate in active sessions.
- Although not actively recruiting volunteers, we continue to respond to any requests for information from anyone hoping to carry out fieldwork projects and to give advice where we can.

The provision of written articles about the work and content of the RESP is an area under development at the moment and includes:

iPRES paper: 'A Tartan Rather than a Plain Cloth': Building a Shared Workflow to Preserve the Regional Ethnology of Scotland Archive, delivered by Sara Day Thomson, Digital Archivist, CRC, at iPRES22, in Glasgow, September 2022.

SRA paper: 'The Regional Ethnology of Scotland Project: Archive and Research in Partnership' based on a paper given by Caroline Milligan and Lesley Bryson at the Scottish Records Association conference in 2022, this paper has been submitted and is awaiting publication.

Visual Resources:

The Past is Still with Us: A 19-minute film about East Lothian fisherman, Charlie Horne, which was shown in local venues and is now available on the RESP Archive website.

Musselburgh Mills: A 42-minute film which brought together the recollections of the main mills in Musselburgh: the paper mill, the wire mill and the net mill. This film, a collaboration with the John Gray Centre in Haddington, was launched in Musselburgh to an audience of over 170 people, many of whom had their own memories of the mills to share and discuss. This film is available to view on the Exhibitions Page of the RESP Archive Project website.

Haddington Voices: A 56-minute film which brings together the recollections of life in Haddington over the years and includes memories about Haddington during World War 2, childhood, town life and change over time. This film will soon be available to view on the Exhibitions Page of the RESP Archive Project website.

Biogs:

Lesley Bryson has been Project Archivist at the Centre for Research Collections, University of Edinburgh since 2007 and the RESP Project Archivist since 2018. Lesley is responsible for resource development, workflow planning and also coordinates and undertakes cataloguing of the RESP Collections.

Caroline Milligan has worked with the EERC and the RESP since 2010, and with the RESP Archive Project since 2018 where she is now the RESP Archives Assistant and Research Officer. Caroline prepares the finding aids for RESP resources being added to the Project website and has an active role in supporting the work of the RESP in the community.